



## INFORMED CONSENT FORM

**Study Title: Exploratory Behavioral Patterns of Herbal Medicine Use among Digitally Connected Syrian Adults: Implications for Arabic Digital Health Resources - Cross-Sectional Survey.**

Protocol Number: SHAMNA-26-04, Approval Date: 10 April 2026, Principal Investigators (Students):

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### 1. Invitation to Participate

You are invited to participate in this research study. Before deciding whether to participate, please read the following information carefully. Participation is entirely voluntary.

Only individuals aged 18 years or older are eligible to participate in this study.

### 2. Purpose of the Study

This cross-sectional survey aims to explore patterns of medicinal plant use among Syrian adults and to examine selected aspects of herbal medicine safety awareness, including perceptions regarding adverse effects and potential herb–drug interactions. The study also seeks to identify common sources of information related to medicinal plants and to assess participants' interest in accessing reliable Arabic-language digital health resources.

### 3. Study Procedures

Participation involves completing a single anonymous online questionnaire consisting of multiple-choice and Likert-type questions. The questionnaire is expected to require approximately 10–15 minutes to complete.

### 4. Voluntary Participation and Right to Withdraw

Participation in this study is completely voluntary. You may refuse to participate or discontinue the questionnaire at any time before submitting your responses without providing a reason and without any negative consequences.

Because no personally identifiable information is collected, once a questionnaire has been submitted it may not be possible to identify and remove an individual response from the dataset.

### 5. Risks and Discomforts

This study involves minimal risk. No medical procedures or interventions are involved. There are no anticipated physical, psychological, or social risks beyond those encountered in everyday life. Some participants may experience minor discomfort when answering questions related to their health-related behaviors or personal opinions.



## **6. Benefits**

There is no direct benefit to individual participants.

However, the findings may contribute to a better understanding of medicinal plant use patterns, herbal medicine safety awareness, and information needs among Syrian adults. The results may help inform future educational initiatives and the development of evidence-based Arabic-language digital health resources.

## **7. Confidentiality and Data Protection**

All information collected in this study will remain strictly confidential and anonymous. No personally identifiable information, including names, email addresses, telephone numbers, workplaces, or identifiable internet data, will be collected.

Survey responses will be stored in secure password-protected systems accessible only to the research team. Data will be analyzed and reported only in aggregated and anonymized form.

Research data may be used in academic publications, conference presentations, and scientific reports, but individual participants will never be identifiable.

Data will be retained for a maximum of two years following study completion and will then be securely destroyed.

## **8. Compensation**

No financial compensation or other incentives will be provided for participation in this study.

## **9. Contact for Questions or Concerns**

If you have any questions regarding this study, please contact: Dr. Chadi Khatib Faculty of Pharmacy, Manara University; Email: [chadi.khatib@manara.edu.sy](mailto:chadi.khatib@manara.edu.sy)

For concerns regarding the ethical conduct of the study, participants may contact the Research Ethics Committee that approved this research.

## **10. Statement of Consent**

I have read and understood the information provided above.

I understand that participation is voluntary and that I may discontinue participation at any time before submitting the questionnaire.

I understand that my responses will be collected anonymously and used for research purposes only.

By clicking “Yes, I agree to participate”, I confirm that I am at least 18 years of age and voluntarily consent to participate in this study.

**By selecting “Yes, I agree to participate,” I provide my informed consent to participate in this study.**

☐ Yes, I agree to participate → Proceed to the questionnaire

☐ No, I do not wish to participate → End of survey